

In Praise of Surpassing the Gods

Devānīśayastotra · Toh 1112 · Derge Tengyur

ལྟལམ་ཕུལ་དུ་བར་བསྟོད།

Toh 1112 in the Tengyur is a devotional hymn known in English as "In Praise of Surpassing the Gods," with the Sanskrit title Deva Atiśaya Stotra and the Tibetan Lha las phul du byung bar bstod pa. It is a stotra, or praise poem, that extols the Buddha as supremely worthy of veneration by contrasting his peaceful, transcendent qualities with the violence and limitations attributed to major Hindu deities such as Viṣṇu, Brahmā, and Śiva. Through a series of pointed comparisons, the text argues that the Buddha's serene and boundless nature surpasses anything these gods embody, making him alone the true object of homage. As Toh 1112 in the Tengyur, it belongs to the collection of Indian scholarly and devotional works preserved in Tibetan translation, and falls within the broader category of stotra literature celebrating the Buddha's incomparable qualities.

In the language of India: Deva Atiśaya Stotra. In the language of Tibet: In Praise of Surpassing the Gods.

Homage to all the Tathāgatas.

The Blessed One, the Sugata, is not accessible to direct perception, nor is he Viṣṇu. Brahmā has not seen him, nor has the Great God (Śiva) perceived him. Hearing of their forms, their power, their conduct, and their thoughts, let one examine who truly has good qualities and who does not.

Viṣṇu strives while bearing a great army, weapons, and a club. The Great God displays a garland of human skulls. If the appearance of a buddha is in every way the summit of peace, then consider which of these — the one who is at peace, or the one who is not — is worthy of veneration.

It is well-known that Viṣṇu destroyed whole lineages in battles too fierce to withstand, and that the Great God razed the triple citadel. Śukra, too, stabbed with a short spear and killed the cranes. The buddha alone acts as physician for all beings.

"I will harm this one, I will protect this one, I will kill this one" — such is the standard teaching of the highest among the gods. The buddha, by contrast, has neither enemy nor friend, yet through certainty, through the excellent and the transcendent, he bestows benefit.

Viṣṇu alone generates faults such as attachment and the rest. The conduct of the Great God is like that of a madman. Since the Tathāgata removes every last fault, consider carefully who is fit to be called the Great Teacher.

One being devoid of kindness strives only to harm others; the other is the one to whom beings have gone for refuge. One is accompanied by attachment, the other is utterly free from attachment. Weigh these two and then speak: which of them, here and now, deserves worship?

Śakra (Indra) holds the vajra and is called the powerful one bearing the balance; Viṣṇu holds the discus-weapon; Śukra holds a short spear; the Great God holds a three-pointed weapon and dwells in charnel grounds. These are childish ones, devoid of loving care, bearing various weapons, threatened by the terror of suffering — perpetually striving to destroy living creatures. What wise person would bow to them?

One who does not carry the three-pointed weapon is without a consort when afflicted by passion; he carries no wrathful discus or fierce spear. Freed from affliction, the wise one strives wholeheartedly to benefit others. To this sage who has become the refuge of the world, I here go for refuge.

The Great God, overcome by desire, casts aside all shame and takes a low-caste woman as consort. Viṣṇu is particularly fierce; his actions are destructive; Śukra even kills his own relatives. The averted calamity — the wrathful one who slays buffaloes — and the mātṛs consume human flesh. These misleaders, despite possessing the power of the great ten strengths, have not even a small fault? Not a single one.

The Blessed One is not my kinsman, nor are the other tīrthikas my enemies. I have not seen the conduct of those others directly for myself. Yet from hearing their words and deeds, and learning of their respective distinctions, because the qualities of the buddha are supremely excellent, out of faith I take him as my refuge.

The Sugata is not my father; the other tīrthikas are not my enemies. That Tathāgata has not given me wealth, nor has he taken anything away from me — not even a sesame seed or a morsel of food. Yet the buddha, the Blessed One, alone, it is said, acts as physician for all beings. To one who is stainless, who removes all stains, in him do I place my faith.

One who always delights in benefit and continually strives to help all beings, one who relieves sentient beings oppressed by the many forms of suffering

and brings them happiness, one who knows all that can be known as clearly as something held in the palm of the hand — to that peerless sage possessed of such qualities, I have turned with confident faith.

Whether from sincere heartfelt faith and joy, whether from doubt, or even for the sake of appearances before others — whoever pays homage to that powerful Sage, that moon, obtains the excellent happiness of the gods.

In ancient times, Viṣṇu obtained dominion over birth, old age, sickness, and death in this world, and then —

— with a mind of extraordinary compassion and earnest effort to protect humanity, he took birth in the Śākya lineage as Gautama, and it is heard that on this earth he became a buddha.

Foolish, afflicted, and bewildered, ordinary beings do not recognize the benefit the Teacher bestows.

When with attachment and aversion they steal treasures from the homes of the asuras (demigods),

and with intellects clouded by desire commit treachery to seize lands — still, in that very hour, they worship and pay homage to Viṣṇu, who is himself unliberated.

Yet though the buddha has truly attained complete liberation, most ordinary people, in their bewilderment, do not bow to him.

This earth, weighed down by the burden of girdle-ropes made from the four oceans,

sits heavily — even if Viṣṇu were to grant his blessing, it would remain a place of great suffering.

But by offering even a single particle of dust to the Sage, the Victor free of sorrow

reaches all across the earth, clothed in the moonlit rays shining from the orb of the moon.

I take no partisan side in favor of the buddhists,
nor do I bear ill will toward the yellow-robed and others —
whatever words are endowed with reason,
that alone I embrace and present as the truth.

For whoever it may be, if they truly possess omniscience
and are great in the manner of bringing benefit solely to beings —
searching for such a one with the keen eye of careful intelligence,

one should rely on that person. What need has the wise for anything else?

If there were one in whom all faults are absent
and all good qualities are present,
then even Brahmā, Viṣṇu, and the great Sovereign Śiva —
even they would be my Teacher.

One who is utterly without fault,
who possesses immeasurable good qualities,
who is omniscient and filled with compassion —
to that one I go for refuge.

With eyes long and wide as the opened petals of a lotus,
I have praised that ocean with a thousand rivers of eulogy.
Whatever small virtue has been created by my words —
by that may all sentient beings be endowed with happiness.

The Praise Excelling the Gods, composed by the master Sukhakara-svāmin, is complete.

Translated by the Indian paṇḍita Sarvajñādeva and the Tibetan translator Bandé Rinchen Chok, with the great editorial revision of the lo tsā ba —

Translator's Notes

- The title in Sanskrit transliteration reads "Deva Atīśaya Stotra," meaning "Praise of Surpassing the Gods." This is not to be confused with the Tibetan master Atīśa; the Sanskrit compound means "extraordinary" or "surpassing excellence."

The figure referred to as Śukra in the stanza about the short spear, cranes, and killing of relatives is the divine preceptor of the asuras, known in Sanskrit as Śukra or Uśanas. The Tibetan term "skems byed" literally means "the desiccating one," a well-known epithet for Śukra. He appears in the myth where he kills a crane with a short spear. The translation renders his name consistently as Śukra.

The phrase "averted calamity" in the difficult stanza about the mātṛs translates "dka' bzlog," literally "repeller of difficulties," which is likely a kenning or epithet used in this context for a fierce deity associated with the mātṛ goddesses; the passage is somewhat compressed and the referents shift rapidly.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage with "and then —"; this is a genuine textual truncation in the source provided and is not a translation error.

- The colophon trails off mid-phrase, ending with "the great editorial revision of the lo tsā ba" without naming the revising translator; the Tibetan text as given is simply incomplete at that point.

The line rendered "sits heavily — even if Viṣṇu were to grant his blessing, it would remain a place of great suffering" is dense and somewhat elliptical. The image is that the four oceans function as ropes girdling the earth, and that even Viṣṇu's famed power and blessing cannot lift the world free of its suffering — a deliberate contrast with the liberating effect of even a mote of dust offered to the Buddha.

The phrase "yellow-robed and others" refers to non-Buddhist ascetics, particularly Jain monks, who wear or go without distinctive robes; the author is declaring impartiality across all traditions.